Isaac Tucker

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Education

2021 - 2027 Ph.D. in Management - UCLA Anderson
Committee: Olav Sorenson, Robert Fairlie, Ashvin Gandhi, David Rigby
Job Market Paper: Performance as a Random Variable

2011 - 2012 M.A. in Geopolitics and the Global Economy - University College Dublin

2008 - 2011 B.A. in Geography - University of California, Los Angeles

Research

Searching for Serendipity with Martin Gonzalez-Cabello and Olav Sorenson)
(*Revise and Resubmit at Strategic Management Journal*)

Serendipity would seem to preclude purposeful search. To understand the relationship between search and the probability of serendipitous discovery, we build a formal model of the process, an extension of the NK model. We show that searchers guided by theory find unexpected solutions to their problems far more often than error-prone or random agents. Those who search longer, regardless of the reason, more frequently encounter solutions to problems that they had not been trying to solve. But these unanticipated use cases may represent distractions: our simulations also suggest that those searching might have found even better solutions to their original problems had they not been seduced by their serendipitous discoveries.

Performance as a Random Variable
(Job Market Paper, Under Review at Strategic Management Journal as of July 2026)

Individual performance is stochastic, but strategic human capital research evaluates workers and policies only in terms of mean or expected performance. This omission embeds strong, rarely stated assumptions about organizations' ability to absorb bad draws and capitalize on good ones. Using a portfolio model, I show that many small, poor, fragile or interdependent organizations pay a "Volatility Tax" and should favor reliability. Large, well-capitalized, or modular organizations can ignore the spread of performance and focus only on the mean. I develop this insight as Human Capital Portfolio Management and discuss implications for strategy, entrepreneurship, and organizational theory.

Playing the Spread: Worker Reliability and Organizational Performance
(Under Review at Organization Science as of September 2026)

Workers have good days and bad days, but strategic human capital management research overwhelmingly focuses on mean performance. This paper examines whether organizations recognize and price worker volatility when they can measure it, and whether they should. Using data from professional basketball, I document both wage and production penalties for volatile workers. After separating persistent volatility from playing-time noise, more volatile workers earn less on the margin where contracts are negotiable. A difference-in-differences design then exploits the quasi-random timing of absences as an identifying shock. Holding mean performance fixed, losing a reliable worker inflicts a larger penalty on organizational outcomes than losing a volatile one. I show that the steadiest workers are eighty percent as costly to lose as a top-quintile player (near-stars through superstars), at forty percent of the salary. Though the production benefits of reliability are contemporaneous, the wage premium exists only for workers with a track record of consistency. If organizations learn a worker's consistency before the market does, this gap may represent an opportunity for competitive advantage.

Entrepreneurial Theories and the Problem of Attribution
(*Working Paper*)

Entrepreneurs hold and execute complex theories of value. These sets of causal claims and probabilistic representations can be tested and revised in response to feedback. However, market feedback typically arrives on the conjecture as a whole, rather than on its individual premises. Differences in founder-specific rules for the attribution of blame or credit and subsequent belief revision can produce markedly different responses to the same feedback. We model entrepreneurs as operating within an ecosystem of beliefs and theories and show how attribution rules, contingent conjectures, and even beliefs unrelated to the focal strategy can shape its revision. These processes can generate persistence, substitution, contraction, or wholesale revision, and produce a stable core of beliefs without imposing one in advance. We then characterize the optimal test or experiment for an entrepreneur to execute as a function of their latent belief structure and attribution rule. Testing the weakest premise emerges as a special case, while optimal experiments may bundle multiple premises. Our framework has implications for the theory-based view of strategy and emerging approaches to entrepreneurial education.

Shake the Snowglobe: Platform Search and Content Discovery with Angela Tran
(*Working Paper*)

Content platforms frequently modify the algorithms that compensate creators and serve content to users. These unpopular changes are typically considered to be a form of value capture at the expense of creators, but this explanation fails to fully explain observed behavior. We argue, instead, that frequent, small-scale destabilization of the creator ecosystem stimulates a form of search that the platform is unable to specify ex-ante and unwilling to compensate ex-post. We develop a formal model of a multi-dimensional content space and test a variety of perturbations. The ideal platform strategy is to cede known or mature niches to a handful of superstar creators while pushing others out into the unknown. Some of this creator diaspora departs the platform, but others will find new types of content that the platform can monetize.

Mapping Knowledge Space and Technological Relatedness in US Cities
(with Dieter F. Kogler and David L. Rigby)
European Planning Studies (2013), 21:9, 1374-1391

An extension of my M.A. dissertation many years ago.

Conference Presentations

2026 - Consortium on Competitiveness and Cooperation
2026 - Academy of Management Annual Meeting
2026 - Strategic Management Society Annual Meeting (PhD Paper Prize Finalist)

Teaching

2025 - 2026	Entrepreneurship and Venture Initiation - Lead Instructor
2025 - 2026	Introduction to Strategy - TA for Tim Gubler
2024 - 2025	Market Entry Strategy - TA for Marvin Lieberman
2024 - 2025	General Management - TA for Ian Larkin
2023 - 2024	Introduction to Strategy - TA for Ashvin Gandhi
2022 - 2023	Entrepreneurship and New Venture Initiation - TA for Olav Sorenson
2022 - 2023	Private Equity and Venture Capital - TA for Olav Sorenson

Service

2026	Reviewer - Journal of Business Venturing
2026	Reviewer - Academy of Management Annual Meeting
2026	Admit Day Coordinator for Strategy, M&O, BDM, and Marketing
2022 - 2024	Admit Day Coordinator for Strategy Department

Professional Experience

2018 - 2021	Chief Product Officer - BlackLine
2016 - 2018	Vice President, Product Management - BlackLine
2015 - 2016	Director, Product Management - BlackLine
2013 - 2015	Director, Mid-Market Sales and Marketing - BlackLine
2012 - 2014	Director, Digital Marketing - BlackLine
2009 - 2012	Solutions Consultant - BlackLine

Community

2022 -	Founding Board Member and Chair - Los Angeles Public Press
2020 - 2023	Member | Board Member - California Donor Table
2019 - 2022	Member - Voices for Progress